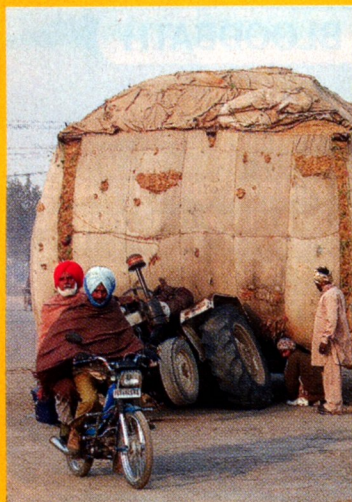


"Most people use their car as a murder weapon as they drive with intense rage. Speed thrills also calm them down."

RAJAT MITRA, *Criminal Psychologist*



OVERLOAD FACTOR

On May 29, 2009, seven people, including three policemen, died and 11 others were critically injured when a truck ran over them on the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway. The mishap happened when an overloaded tractor trolley overturned and policemen trying to rescue a man stuck in the trolley were hit by the speeding vehicle. Similarly, in March 2009, a 19-year-old student, Rahul Anand, died trying to save a pedestrian on the Gurgaon Expressway, making him one of the 160 people killed on this road.

HIGH SPEED EXPRESSWAYS ARE BECOMING DEATH TRAPS BECAUSE OF A LACK OF PEDESTRIAN SUBWAYS AND OVERBRIDGES.

COMPARISON WITH THE US

A high number of vehicles is no indicator of higher road fatality

	INDIA	USA
		
Population	114,79,95,904	30,40,59,724
Total vehicles	7,27,18,000	46,98,51,833
Total road accidents	4,18,600	64,20,000
Total road fatalities	1,14,590	42,636
Total road injuries	4,65,300	29,00,000
Average road fatalities per hour	13	Nearly 5
Ratio between injured and dead	5:1	69:1

The US has six times more vehicles and experiences nearly 15 times more road accidents, but its road fatality figure is 37 per cent of India's. The key difference is in the profile of victims: in India, it is primarily pedestrians, cyclists and two-wheelers while in the US it is car drivers.

proper locations contribute in a major way to road accidents.

Not surprisingly, the cities that have the most road accident deaths (see box) are also the ones that rank high on road rage cases, suggesting a connection between urban stress and pressures and poor traffic management. "Many people drive with intense rage. They have no fear of the consequences of driving dangerously," says Rajat Mitra, a criminal psychologist who heads the Swanchetan Society for Mental Health. The lack of fear is directly linked to weak laws, lack of deterrents and weaker implementation. In India, it is common to see motorcycles being driven at high speed by riders without helmets. In most countries, this is a major crime. More than one serious driving offence can lead to the cancellation of the licence but in India, no such deterrent exists.

Nanda was jailed for drunken driving because his case became a media

sensation and he came from a high profile family. In most cases, the matter gets sorted out with the payment of money to the victims, who are mostly poor. This informal and out-of-court settlement is brokered with the help of policemen who also earn a cut. While drunken driving and dangerous driving remain the only cognizable offences under the Motor Vehicle Act of 1988, the level of conviction is abysmally low. That is something the Supreme Court knows all too well. In March, after a 16-year-old boy died due to a bus-autorickshaw collision, the trial court imposed a sentence of one-year imprisonment and a fine of Rs 5,000. However, the Karnataka High Court allowed the driver's appeal by increasing the fine amount in lieu of doing away with the jail term. The apex court bench had to intervene and dismissed the high court order, saying: "Any liberal attitude by imposing meagre sentences or taking too sympa-

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PER CENT INCREASE IN AVERAGE SPEED LEADS TO A 30 PER CENT INCREASE IN ROAD ACCIDENT FATALITIES.